Teenage Waistland

By Abby Ellin

INTRODUCTION

If your son or daughter is overweight, if you and your family struggle with "food issues," you've probably had your fill of news about the "childhood obesity epidemic." Abby Ellin, a journalist and former fat-camp attendee, has an abiding compassion for overweight kids. In "Teenage Waistland" she shares the story of her family's attempts to "save her" from obesity and explores how they might have done it better. Teenage Waistland by Abby Ellin.

I was ten the first time I stepped on a scale. It was the summer of 1978, and I was visiting my grandmother in Florida.

Each morning I woke up in her big bed and she smothered me with kisses. "Good morning, beautiful!" she'd sing, and ask what I wanted for breakfast. She'd set up a tray for me while I lounged in bed and watched Phil Donahue. In the afternoon, Grandma and I would go for our daily two-mile walk, past the golf course. On the way home we'd stop there to weigh ourselves on the gigantic outdoor scale. "Girls have to be thin and beautiful," Grandma would say, always linking the two adjectives together. "The world judges on first appearances."

The routine was the same every day: we'd wait in line behind the old ladies while they handed their packages to their husbands, who seemed tolerant and bored. The women stepped on and off, and then Grandma got on. She didn't look like you'd expect a grandmother to look, soft and round and smelling of gingerbread. No, this Grandma was all sharp angles and points; her make-up and hair carefully arranged, her clothes stylish and neatly pressed. She was interested in modern art, theater,

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movies, clothes, she took great pride in her appearance, especially her weight. She was skinny, and the needle hovered around 120.

Then it was my turn. Was I ever really fat? Well, no, I suppose. Not technically. As a child I was a gymnast, muscular, firm; my greatest pleasure was going to gymnastics and coming home to a large cheese pizza, oil dripping on my leotard and tights. I loved peppermint stick ice cream, fruit-flavored jelly beans, Duncan Hines chocolate frosting.

I can't recall a time when I wasn't conscious that fat was bad. My mother had taped a picture onto the refrigerator of an obese woman rifling through a freezer, a warning of the dangers lurking behind that door. My older sister and I were constantly cautioned by my mother and grandmother never to gain weight. In our minds, getting fat was a terrible tragedy, the worst fate to befall a person. Fat was ugly, undignified, a sign of weakness and failure. But though I was aware of this, I never really worried about it. I could inhale tons of food and burn it off at the gym. Fat, like fatal car crashes or terminal illnesses, was something that happened to other people.

I'm not quite sure how the weight- gain began; it built up gradually, tentatively, so slowly I hardly noticed. My interest in food acquired an obsessive quality that, looking back, seems like the early seeds of an addiction. Not surprisingly, food stopped being a source of pleasure and became, instead, the enemy. My body will never be as slight as Kate Moss's (will anyone's?), but as an adolescent I yearned for nothing more than matchstick legs and pelvic bones as sharp as steak knives.

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I desperately wanted to be thin, but I resented the sacrifice. One of my few delights was eating--why deny myself? (After the initial horror of 9/11 dimmed, my philosophy was, "Well, if the terrorists are going to get us, we might as well eat...")

5 years later, when I was 15, my Florida grandmother came to visit. As usual, she looked wonderful, her nails newly manicured, her clothes freshly pressed. She kissed me hesitantly, her hands kneading the strange new flesh on my shoulders and back. She was horrified.

Later, I overheard her telling my mother that I'd gotten "tremendous." At dinner, I reached for a second slice of kugel, and my grandmother slapped my hands away. "You don't need another," she said. "How can you let yourself go like this? You've got such a gorgeous face--don't you want boys to like you? Don't you care what people think when they see you?"

"Ma, don't," my mother said, dipping an apple sliver into a bowl of honey.

"You've got to get hold of yourself," Grandma continued. "You need to lose fifteen pounds or else you can't come to Florida this Christmas."

"But why?" I said, tears burning my eyes. "Who cares what I weigh?"

"Because the world judges on first appearances," Grandma snapped.
"Don't argue with me. It's my home and I don't want you there unless you look the way you're supposed to."

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"But it's a big state," I stammered, trying to joke. "I can fit."

"No," she said, and I knew she meant it. I was devastated. I'm sure my grandmother meant well, and was only doing what she thought was helpful. Over the next few months she clipped diets from magazines and mailed them to me. Her favorite was the Weigh of Life, a program that incorporated fruits, vegetables, and lots of protein into a daily regimen. Her passion was militant. "You really have to look at this as a way of life," Grandma said over the telephone. "You've got to think of fattening foods as poison--things that will kill you if you eat them."

My mother tried to help. She cooked low-fat, low-calorie meals, weighed and measured everything on my plate. She labeled the food in the refrigerator. Healthy stuff had my name taped on it, the more fattening stuff was for my father, brother, or "company." I tried to be good, tried to eat salads without dressing and only one slice of pizza. And yet I constantly wondered why I was depriving myself.

Would lead roles come my way if I got thin? Would the National Merit Scholarship people call me? Would guys pound on my door until it caved in? Part of me doubted this, while another part "did" believe my life would magically transform itself once I knocked off ten pounds. And so I kept trying, but that would only last a few days. Then my body would feel weak and sluggish and my thoughts would focus on what I wanted to eat and what I couldn't eat and why I couldn't eat it. Sometimes the hunger was so bad I'd rummage through my mother's purse and pluck out a ten- or

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twenty-dollar bill. I'd stuff it into my pocket and head to the nearest supermarket, buying boxes of Twinkies and bags of jelly beans. I buried them in my middle drawer, beneath my bras and collection of foreign currency, locking my bedroom door while I ate.

I wasn't the only one who hid food. Every so often I'd open a cabinet, a storage bin, and find chocolate or donut holes stuffed into brown paper bags. Once I even discovered an apple pie in the trunk of mother's Cadillac. I'd slip the goodies inside my shirt and sneak upstairs to my room. The next day I'd shove the wrappers in my knapsack and toss them into a garbage can at school. One day I came home from school to find my mother waiting for me, an empty box of Devil Dogs in hand. "Where the h ell did this go?"

I shrugged and flipped my palms, looked her straight in the eye. "How would I know? I didn't even know you had that," I lied. "Ask your other children."

My mother laughed sadly. "Ray's too young, and you know your sister wouldn't eat that. She won't eat anything."

That was true. While I was getting bigger, my sister was still wasting away, her bones sticking out like wire hangers, her belt cinched twice around her waist. She'd lock herself in her room for hours, doing sit-ups and leg lifts. She'd actually removed the mattress from her canopy bed, installed a weight set where the bed used to be, and slept on the floor. Why my parents let her do this still puzzles me. I guess it was easier to give in than to fight.

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At mealtimes my mother's eyes would dart between my plate, which was full, and my sister's, which was organized like a closet: chicken in one compartment, peas in another, mashed potatoes in a third. She chopped her food into sixteenths, chewed each piece twenty times, careful not to let her fork touch her lips. She still exercised daily, running five, six times around the reservoir.

"Where did you hide that?" I asked, trapping her. "'Why did you hide that?"

My mother looked at me and then at the empty box of Devil Dogs, back and forth, back and forth, as if the answer lay in the space between. "Because you're fat," she said finally. "I love you, but you're fat."

I jerked backwards, as if she had punched me in the gut. "Then how can you love me?"

Did she worry about me? And if not, why did she give me so much grief for being overweight? "I didn't worry that you'd get sick because you were fat, but I worried that you would suffer the consequences of a society that viewed slenderness as desirable," she said. "I didn't know what to do. I did the best I could."

"The best I could. The best I could." At the time, that wasn't enough, but now that I'm older I get it. I understand her frustration, and her inability to do the "right" thing. Is there "ever" a right thing when it comes to parenting?

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I'm betting this sounds familiar to you, too, especially if you are or have ever been a fat kid. If you're the parent of one you might see yourself in my mother, faced with a child who has some kind of weight problem, and not knowing what to do. And so you try anything and everything: modeling calorie-conscious behavior; storing healthy food in the cupboard; supporting his or her efforts to diet and exercise; trying behavior modification and setting up rewards for success. But you mainly succeed in making your kid feel bad, ugly, angry, guilty, and miserable.

Only now, with friends stumbling through parenthood, do I really get what my own folks had to deal with and how absolutely flummoxed they were. You never know how your kid is going to turn out, but I doubt my parents expected their two daughters to spend their adolescences fixated on weight. It's fascinating, if you think about it: My sister and I both received the same messages about fat, but we handled them so differently. What made me internalize them one way and her go the other route? What made her shun food, and me run toward it? And what the hell should my parents have done for either of us? It must have been heartbreaking for them, desperately wanting to help their kids while being utterly incapable.

Not that I let them off the hook completely. I spent years condemning my folks (well, mostly my mother) for even making food an issue in the house. If my mother had her own issues under wraps, I believed, my sister and I would never have had to suffer. I still believe this is true, but I don't resent my mother--or even my grandmother--anymore. Now that I'm older, I feel bad for them, for all of us. It's

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hard enough just to survive on this planet; most people are simply doing the best they can. Yes, some people absolutely have no business reproducing. But the average person--my own parents, you--truly wants what's best for their kids. If they only knew what that was, or how to bring it about, things would be a lot easier.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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